ERA 8

The Mexican-American War

1846 – 1848

The war · the Mexican Cession · the Wilmot Proviso

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

How did the Mexican-American War expand the nation—and reignite the fight over slavery?

KEY TERMS

Mexican-American War · Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo · Mexican Cession · Wilmot Proviso

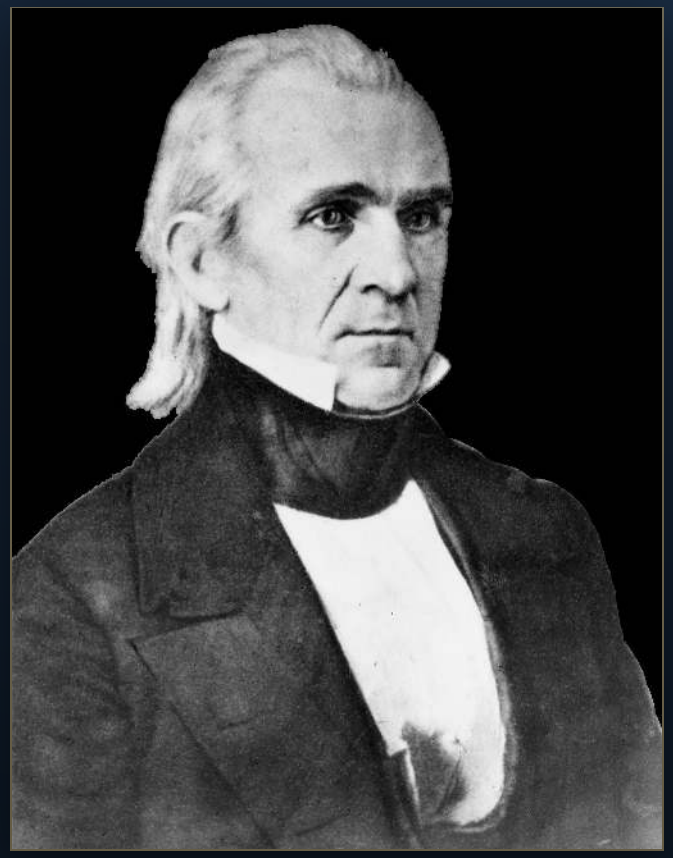
ALIGNED TO

CED Topic 5.3 · AMSCO Ch. 5.3

SECTION

The Road to War

President Polk & Expansion



- Expansionist **James K. Polk** won the 1844 election.
- Texas was annexed as the 28th state in December 1845.
- **Polk** was determined to acquire California and the Southwest, too.

How the War Began

DISPUTE

The Border

The U.S. and Mexico disagreed over the Texas boundary.

→

PROVOCATION

Taylor at the Rio Grande

Polk sends Zachary Taylor into disputed land.

→

CLASH

'American Blood'

A skirmish gives Polk his reason for war.

→

WAR

Congress Declares

Congress declares war on Mexico in May 1846.

SECTION

The War

Marching to Mexico City



- U.S. forces under **Taylor** and **Winfield Scott** won victory after victory.
- By September 1847 they captured Mexico City itself.
- The war was swift—but bloody and controversial.

A Controversial War

- Many **Northerners** opposed the war as a plot to expand slavery.
- Critics like Thoreau and a young Abraham Lincoln questioned its justice.
- The war deepened the sectional divide even as it was won.



SECTION

Victory & Its Price

The Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo, 1848



- Mexico ceded the **Mexican Cession**—California and the Southwest.
- The U.S. paid $15 million and set the border at the **Rio Grande**.
- The nation grew by a third—fulfilling **Manifest Destiny**.

SECTION

A Dangerous Question

The Wilmot Proviso

PROPOSAL

Ban Slavery

The Wilmot Proviso would bar slavery from all lands won from Mexico.

→

REACTION

The South Blocks It

Southern senators kill the measure.

→

RESULT

Crisis Reopened

The question of slavery in the West splits the nation anew.

Who Lived in California?

PEOPLE

Californios

Spanish-speaking Mexican residents of California, many of them landowning ranch families. After the U.S. took California in 1848, many lost their land through costly legal challenges and the Gold Rush rush of settlers, despite promises in the Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

The Mexican-American War

1. A **border dispute** and **Polk**'s expansionism led Congress to declare the **Mexican-American War**.
2. Victory brought the vast **Mexican Cession** through the **Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo** (1848).
3. The **Wilmot Proviso** turned the new territory into a battleground over slavery—reigniting the **sectional crisis**.

DISCUSS & APPLY

The Mexican-American War

AP HISTORICAL REASONING PRACTICE

CAUSATION

Explain how a **border dispute** escalated into a full war with Mexico.

ARGUMENTATION

Critics called it an unjust war of aggression. Using today's evidence, make and defend a claim: was the war justified?

CONTINUITY & CHANGE

Explain how the **Wilmot Proviso** turned a war of expansion into a crisis over slavery.

Up next — **Lesson 20: The Slave South** (cotton, the enslaved experience & resistance)